ShelterLink

How it works for volunteers and staff · Assisi demo guide

What it is. ShelterLink is a volunteer system built for animal shelters, with the animals in it. Staff run the day from a browser. Volunteers pick shifts, foster, and message without sharing phone numbers. It is meant to replace paper rotas, WhatsApp groups, and spreadsheet hours.

1. Demo logins (this copy only)

Open `http://localhost:3001` while the app is running (`npm run dev`). On a development copy the login page shows a Demo accounts card.

Role	Email	Password	What you see
Admin / staff	`admin@shelterlink.org`	`Admin123!`	Day sheet, animals, volunteers, onboarding, messages, reports
Volunteer	`alex.jenkins@example.com`	`Password1`	Browse shifts, foster, transport, hours, messages, profile

Other seeded volunteers also use password `Password1`. These accounts exist only because sample data was loaded. **Do not use them on a live shelter site.** For a real deploy you create a real admin and turn seed data off.

2. Two sides of the same system

Everyone uses the same website. After login, ShelterLink shows a different menu depending on the account.

Volunteers	Admin / staff
Register, complete a profile, wait for approval, then apply for shifts.	Approve new people, create shifts, print the day/week sheet, fill gaps.
See animals on a shift (name, photo, handling notes). Log walk / feed / socialise.	Keep animal records, handling notes, and staff-only welfare / incident notes.
Offer to foster if their home matches. Claim a transport leg if they drive.	Post foster requests, confirm placements, set up relay runs with claimable legs.

Volunteers	Admin / staff
Chat about a shift by first name only. Never see another volunteer's phone or email.	Read every thread, post announcements, soft-delete messages if needed.
Log hours, collect badges, download a service certificate.	Approve hours, track AccessNI and references, see who is stuck in onboarding.

3. Volunteer path

1. **Register** with name, email, phone, and a password. They are not fully active until staff approve the profile.
2. **Complete profile** — availability, tags, foster home details (garden, other animals, children, medication), away mode if they are on holiday.
3. **Onboarding checklist** on the dashboard: profile, waiver, references, AccessNI where required. They can see what is waiting on them vs waiting on the shelter.
4. **Browse shifts** — open slots, animals on the shift, handling notes ("muzzle required", "pulls left"). Apply once. Full shifts can waitlist.
5. **Show up** — check in with a code or kiosk. After the shift they log hours and animal activity (walk / feed / socialise).
6. **Foster** — they only see requests they match. They offer; staff confirm one carer. Emergency phone is shown to active foster carers.
7. **Transport** — claim one leg of a relay. They do not see the next driver's phone; handover goes through the shelter.
8. **Messages** — shift, foster, and transport threads. Names only between volunteers.
9. **Impact** — hours, badges, animals helped, printable certificate. Calendar / ICS for their phone.

Volunteers can also install ShelterLink as a phone app (PWA) from the browser. There is no App Store build.

4. Admin / staff path

Log in as admin, then work from the **Staff guide** in this order on a typical morning:

1. **Day sheet** — today's roster, phones, emergency contacts, animal photos and handling notes. Print for reception.
2. **Week sheet** — who is on site this week, plus ICS download.
3. **Check-ins** — codes on the day sheet, or the tablet kiosk at reception.
4. **Urgent cover** — flag an understaffed shift. Matching approved volunteers get email (and push, if keys are set). No phone tree.

5. **Animals** — residents linked to shifts. Add a staff-only welfare / incident note when something happens.
6. **Messages** — unread shift and foster threads instead of WhatsApp.
7. **Fosters** — post a request, review offers, confirm a placement, end it when the animal comes back.
8. **Transport** — a run with ordered legs. See who has claimed and which gap still needs a driver.
9. **Applications and hours** — accept people onto shifts; approve yesterday's hours so badges stay true.
10. **Onboarding** — pipeline of who is stuck on waiver, references, or AccessNI.
11. **Privacy** — export or erase a volunteer; staff keep contact details, volunteers never see each other's.

Staff can also save shift **templates** (morning walks, cattery, kennel clean), clone a shift, and add a shift note such as "bring wellies".

5. How a shift actually moves

1. Staff create a shift (or from a template), optionally attach animals and a required qualification or AccessNI level.
2. Approved volunteers apply. If the slot is full they waitlist. If they lack a qualification or check, they are blocked with a clear reason.
3. Staff accept (or the system fills by policy). A thread exists for that shift when someone messages.
4. On the day: check-in, handling notes on the day sheet, activity logged against named animals.
5. Volunteer logs hours → staff approve → badges / certificate update.

> **Privacy promise you can say out loud.** Volunteers see other volunteers' names, never their email, phone, or address. Staff and admins still have contacts for emergencies. Transport handovers and shift chat follow the same rule.

6. Can you host this on Vercel so they can use it?

No. Do not put ShelterLink on Vercel. Volunteers and staff would not get a reliable app.

> Vercel is built for websites that wake up per request and then sleep. ShelterLink is a long-running Node/Express server. It keeps login sessions in Postgres, sends shift reminders, weekly digests, and a daily "keep the database awake" ping. If the process sleeps, reminders stop, check-in flows

> glitch, and a free Supabase database can pause. The frontend is also served by that same Express server, not a static Vercel site.

> **What to use instead.** Keep the database on Supabase (already set up). Host the app on an always-on service such as **Railway**, **Render**, or **Fly.io**. Those give you a public HTTPS link (for example `https://shelterlink.up.railway.app`). Staff and volunteers then log in from any phone or computer — same emails and roles, no need to install anything except the optional phone PWA.

For a live shelter (not this demo):

- Build the database *without* sample logins.
- Create a real admin account for coordinators.
- Set a public URL, HTTPS, and email (Brevo or similar) so password resets and urgent cover actually send.
- Demo passwords above must be removed or never loaded.

Until that host is set up, only people on this computer (or on the same network if you share `http://your-mac-ip:3001`) can use the running demo.

7. Quick click-through for a demo

As admin — Staff guide → Day sheet → Week sheet → Animals (add a note) → understaffed shift / urgent cover → Messages → Fosters → Transport → Onboarding → Privacy in the footer.

As volunteer — log out, log in as Alex → dashboard checklist → browse a shift with animals → messages → foster / transport → hours / certificate.

ShelterLink is a self-hosted volunteer system for a single shelter. SMS, donor CRM, and native App Store apps are out of scope. This sheet describes the demo copy with sample data, not a production policy document.